Tactical Planning Part 2

Group

The Tactical Planning Framework

METT-TC -> EMLCOA -> CG/CV/EXP. PLAN
-> SOM -> FSP -> TASKS

Mission

Deny or degrade the Varenskian actor's ability to collect intelligence from the defended Lunovian governments network in order to preserve friendly freedom of maeuver in cyberspace and generate options for pursuit.

CC Intent: "The commander wants to preserve friendly freedom of maneuver, avoid unnecessary disruption to government services, and generate options for pursuit"

- Specified Tasks:
  - Preserve Friendly Freedom of Maneuver
  - Avoid unnecessary disruption to gov't services
  - Generate options for pursuit
- Implied Tasks:
  - Develop accurate battlemap of network
  - Accurately identify adversary actions, CoGs and intent
  - Wargame COAs for pursuit IAW CC Intent

Enemy Analysis: Varensk ISB (SALUTE Report)

- **Size:** well-funded, mature nation-state group, active since 2013
- **Activity:** Spear phishing, HTML Smuggling, Weaponized Word Documents, Weaponized USB, PowerShell / VBScript, Metasploit framework, Persistence: registry autoruns, startup folder, scheduled tasks, services
- **Location:** country Varensk, likely capitol of Karsograd. RFI: physical specific operating facility , RFI for logical operating space
- **Unit:** likely unit Internal Security Bureau (ISB) Unit 18 "Amber Tide" (Gamaerdon copycat)
- **Time:** Active since 2013, most recent campaign Q4 2023 – USB-Driven Internal Spread
- **Equipment:** Metasploit framework, LOL (PowerShell, VBScript, mshta.exe, WMI)

Enemy Capabilities & Limitations (DRAWD)

- **Defend**: (infrastructure access, defensive tools in place, packers, anti-forensics, insider threats?
  - Capability: obfuscation, hidden files, indicator removal
  - Limits: Not much in reporting; RFI? (1)
  - Conditions: Not much in reporting; RFI? (2)
- **Reinforce**: (priv esc, deploy additional tools (establish persistence), who do they contact with their stuff breaks (support structures), chats)
  - Capability: persistence creation (Registry, startup, schtasks, services), lateral movement via USB for extended access
  - Limits: Not much in reporting; RFI? (3)
  - Conditions: will attempt to establish persistence and lateral movement when gaining initial access

Enemy Capabilities & Limitations (DRAWD)

- **Attack**:
  - Capability: exfiltrate files based on specific extensions
  - Limits: tool lifetime/reliability (due to frequent updates, ever-changing obfuscation, and simultaneous deployment of multiple simple downloaders or backdoors to maintain access)
  - Conditions: will likely continue collecting while maintaining access to systems of interest
- **Withdraw:** (remove presence, tools/access to valuable to abandon, conditions?)
  - Capability: Not much in reporting; RFI? (4)
  - Limits: does not prioritize stealth, easily detected
  - Conditions: Not much in reporting; RFI? (5)

Enemy Capabilities & Limitations (DRAWD)

- **Delay**: (disrupt our analysis/response actions, data wiping, misdirection, anti-forensics)
  - Capability: obfuscation , encrypted files, mshta.eze proxy, double file extensions
  - Limits: none from reporting (does not prioritize stealth)
  - Conditions: may pivot to stealthier techniques if exfiltration stops

Troops and Fire Support Available (Organic)

- **Analysts:** 4 Host Analysts
- **Operators:** 4 Certified Counter-Strike Operators*
- **Fire Support:** Lunovian Friendly Forces, Volunteer cyber auxiliary
  - National Cyber Defense Agency, Digital Infrux Protection Corps
- **Equipment:** Local Defenders capes: Endpoint telemetry, windows event logs, firewall logs, limited netflow (no full pcap)
- **Attachments:** None.

Terrain Analysis (OCOKAW)

Factor	Friendly Perspective	Enemy Perspective
Observation & Fields of Fire	Endpoint telemetry, windows event logs, FW logs and limited netflow	Logical user access across domains. Potential physical access via USB distrobution
Cover & Concealment	Friendly forces does not employ Cover and concealment for defensive measures	Not stealthy in defender reported activity CTI indicates frequent updates to malware and obfuscation, file masquerading, mshta proxy, hidden files and AMSI bypass
Obstacles	Enemy's rapid execution / PCAP	Local defenders current capabilities are ineffective (FW, logs, endpoint telemetry)
Key Terrain	RFI: Critical Business Processes and related CKT Assumption: Fileserver, router as egress/ingress SPOF	Fileserver Persistence locations singular route and associated eqmt
Avenues of Approach	SIEM (how we come in contact with enemy)	Spearphishing, HTML Smuggling and removable media.
Weather (Cyber)	Potential power outages, river flooding?	Cold AF,

Enemy's Most Likely Course of Action (EMLCOA)

- **Mission:** Primarily focused on cyberespionage against Lunovian gov't institutions, data collection and exfiltration. (To what end/RFI?)
- **Current Action:** Unit 18 under the Varensk Internal Security Bureau is actively exfiltrating **DATA** from a Lunovian government network, targeting users in the energy and transportation sectors.
- **On Contact:** Upon detection, they will likely retool and attempt additional data exfiltration within this network. If Unit 18's access was degraded by cyber forces, It is likely that they would move on to other targets within their rapid and prolific ability to seed access.

The Exploitation Plan

- **Center of Gravity (CG):** The speed at which they exfiltrate data. They prioritize rapid theft over long-term stealth.
- **Critical Vulnerability (CV):** Their eagerness for information and automated data exfiltration. Standardized filetype for data exfil.
- **Exploitation Plan:** Canary file of exceptionally juicy energy and transportation docs. Depending on lawyers, we can either make a **tripwire** file that will notify when moved or an **actual weaponized PDF**.
  - EnergyPlans2026.pdf
  - To Meet CC Intent: Provide options for Pursuit

Scheme of Maneuver (SOM)

- **Phase 1:** Preparation & Baselining**: Set the defense. Identify critical data sources and establish a baseline of "known good" activity.
- **Phase 2:** Near-Real-Time Detection**: Ambush. Deploy "allow-list" SIEM dashboards to alert on any deviation from the baseline.
- **Phase 3:** Isolation & Triage**: Fix the Enemy. Immediately quarantine alerted hosts and conduct live forensics.
- **Phase 4:** Scoping & Hunt**: Exploit and Eradicate. Extract IoCs, hunt for other compromised hosts enterprise-wide, and repeat Phase 3.
- **Phase 5:** Information Dissemination**: Share IoCs and findings with higher echelons.

Fire Support Plan (FSP)

Target Category	Trigger	Organic Action	Rear Echelon Action	Desired Effects
Adversary C2 Infrastructure	Confirmed beaconing from isolated host.	Block outbound traffic; submit RFF.	Conduct active recon & exploit C2 node.	Degrade, Disrupt, Exploit
Adversary Staging Server	Novel payload URL extracted from memory.	Block downloads; submit RFF with URL.	Enumerate/download full toolkit; neutralize server.	Deny, Intelligence Gain
Compromised 3rd-Party Relay	Traffic identified routing through a known proxy.	Null-route traffic; submit RFF.	Coordinate with law enforcement or execute authorized DCORA.	Disrupt

Organic Asset Tasking

Role	Key Responsibilities
Mission Commander (MC)	Authorize key actions (quarantine, RFF submission), manage risk.
Threat Intel	Provide initial TTPs, analyze extracted tools, update EMLCOA.
Network Analyst (NetOps)	Build/monitor SIEM dashboards, trigger alerts, block C2 IPs locally.
Host Analyst (HostOps)	Deploy EDR, execute immediate host quarantine, conduct live triage.

Conclusion & Key Takeaways

- **Tempo is Everything:** Our plan is designed to outpace the adversary's "speed-over-stealth" methodology.
- **Vulnerability Exploitation:** We are directly targeting their reliance on script-based tools and LOLBAS.
- **Integrated Defense:** Success requires a seamless flow of information and action between NetOps, HostOps, and Intel.
- **Unity of Effort:** Clear roles and responsibilities prevent overlap and ensure we can execute the plan under pressure.

Sources

- **UK NCSC:** Russia's FSB Malign Cyber Activity Factsheet
- **Palo Alto Unit 42:** Gamaredon/Primitive Bear Ukraine Update 2021
- **ESET Whitepaper:** The Gamaredon way of Cyberespionage